The Ethical Hacker's Command Handbook

Chapter 2 – Part 10: Nmap Master Cheat Sheet, Common Mistakes & Interview Preparation

Your quick revision guide for labs, interviews, and certification preparation.

20 Essential Nmap Commands

Purpose	Command	Memory Tip
Host Discovery	nmap -sn	Scan No Ports
SYN Scan	nmap -sS	S = SYN
TCP Connect	nmap -sT	T = TCP
UDP Scan	nmap -sU	U = UDP
Version Detection	nmap -sV	V = Version
OS Detection	nmap -O	O = Operating System
Default Scripts	nmap -sC	C = Common Scripts
Aggressive	nmap -A	A = Aggressive
All Ports	nmap -p-	Every Port
Timing	nmap -T4	Fast Labs
Save Results	nmap -oA	All Outputs

Recommended Workflow

1. Host Discovery (-sn)
2. SYN Scan (-sS -p-)
3. Version Detection (-sV)
4. OS Detection (-O)
5. Default NSE Scripts (-sC)
6. Service-Specific NSE Scripts
7. Save Results (-oA)
8. Research and Documentation

Common Beginner Mistakes

- Running -A before basic enumeration.
- Scanning only common ports.
- Ignoring service version detection.
- Not saving scan results.
- Running unnecessary NSE scripts.

Interview Questions

Q: Difference between -sS and -sT?

A: -sS performs a SYN scan, while -sT completes a full TCP connection.

Q: What does -A include?

A: OS detection, version detection, default NSE scripts, and traceroute.

Q: Why use -sV?

A: To identify software versions for further research.

Q: What does -oA do?

A: Saves results in .nmap, .xml, and .gnmap formats.

Q: Why is -T4 popular?

A: It provides a good balance of speed and reliability on most lab networks.

Quick Revision

Host Discovery → Port Scan → Version Detection → OS Detection → Default Scripts → Service-Specific Scripts → Save Results → Research → Documentation